The Door – Government Overreach

Oct 16, 2026 · @Carl

A man is walking down a street. A van pulls up. Three men get out. They are not police, not exactly, and they are not criminals, not legally. They have a list, and his number is on it.

He shouts. He holds on to a railing. A woman across the road starts filming; another runs over and pulls at the arm of one of the men. For a few seconds, ordinary people stand between a man and the state that has come to collect him. Then the door slides shut and the van drives away.

Where it happens doesn't matter. Which flag is painted on the van doesn't matter either. What matters is the thing nobody in the scene was asked: did he agree? This essay is about that question, and about the door the state would prefer you never noticed.

The Given

Let the state speak first, in its own words. They are reasonable words. That is the problem.

> *Every citizen enjoys the protection of the state. In return, the citizen accepts certain obligations. When the nation is threatened, the duty to defend it falls on all equally. This is the social contract. Security is a common good, and defence must therefore be collective; no one may free-ride on the sacrifice of others. Without it, the community would be undefended. Those with genuine objections of conscience may apply for recognition. Conscription is fair because it is universal. It is lawful because it was enacted by the people's representatives. It is temporary, proportionate, and necessary.*

It almost persuades. It is meant to. It reads like a policy paper because that is what it is: the voice of administration, calm and finished, the voice in which every government overreach is announced.

Read it again. Slowly.

The Grammar

Enjoys the protection. He never asked to be protected. Protection you cannot refuse is not a service. It is a claim.

In return. The language of exchange, with no moment of exchange. Nothing was offered, nothing was accepted. The return is collected for a purchase that was never made.

The duty falls on all. Duty falls the way rain falls: no hand, no author, nobody you could ask why. The verb removes whoever sent the van.

Equally. An equal share of being seized.

The social contract. No signature. No date. No copy for the other party. No exit clause. It binds precisely because it was never offered. A contract you cannot see, cannot read and cannot leave is not a contract. It is the word *contract*, borrowed to dress a claim in the clothes of consent. It is the same move as the legal person: a document you never signed, used to bind the one who never signed it.

Collective defence. Three words, each quietly changing its meaning. The *self* being defended is no longer you; it is the state. The *collective* is a will nobody voiced, assembled from people nobody asked. And *defence* sounds protective, but what is defended is a territory and an institution, and what is spent is a person. The phrase that sounds most like your right to protect your own life is the one that takes it.

Free-ride. The cleverest word in the passage. It turns a man who refuses to die into a thief. He has taken nothing. In this grammar, keeping your own life is theft.

Undefended. The word equates defence with the state's army. Remove conscription and it says the community is naked. But a community where nobody is forced to fight is not a community where nobody fights. It is one where those who defend it chose to. *Undefended* turns *unconscripted* into *defenceless*, and the reader nods before noticing the swap.

Apply for recognition. The state does not have refusers. It has *conscientious objectors*, people who object, then submit an application, then wait while an official examines their conscience. The vocabulary turns a no into a request for permission. Your refusal belongs to the state until the state approves it.

Enacted by the people's representatives. Consent by proxy. The proxies were chosen by others, some before he could vote, some before he was born.

Temporary, proportionate, necessary. Three adjectives, each measured by the party doing the taking. And *necessary* is the oldest word of all: *someone must do something*, in uniform. Necessary for whom, it never says.

Now look at the grammar of the whole passage. The state is the subject of every sentence, or the sentence has no subject at all. The man appears only as an object: protected, obliged, defended, recognised, conscripted. There is not one verb in which he

says yes. The case does not fail because its logic is weak. It never needed his consent to be complete. Its persuasiveness lives entirely in its grammar, and the grammar has no place for him.

This is why the men at the van are called *state actors*. They are actors in the plain sense: speaking lines they did not write, in a role they did not author. The official with the list did not write the list. The legislator did not invent the necessity. Follow the script back and you find no author, only the script. It does not need anyone to believe it. It only needs everyone to keep speaking it.

The Best Case

And there is nowhere to run: most states do not conscript today, but every one keeps the power to begin, and not one guarantees a person the plain right to say no.

Be fair to the state. Look at the places that come closest to asking.

Switzerland is the usual answer. Its defence is a militia, not a standing army: citizens train, go home, and traditionally keep the rifle in the house. It is local, distributed, organised around the valleys and the cantons. It is armed neutrality, with no foreign wars. And the Swiss have been asked. In 1989 about a third of voters chose to abolish the army altogether. In 2013 roughly three-quarters voted to keep compulsory service.

But the Swiss conscript. The man who voted no still receives the call-up. A referendum turns *the people decided* into law; it never turns it into *you agreed*. It is consent by proxy, with a better turnout.

Norway goes further: a recognised objector is exempt, with no alternative service to perform. But he must still apply, an official must still judge his conscience, and in a crisis the exemption lapses.

Iceland goes furthest of all. It has never conscripted anyone and has no army. After the crash of 2008, its citizens wrote a new constitution themselves, and Article 31 of their draft prohibited compulsory military service outright. In 2012 the people approved it in a non-binding referendum. In 2013 parliament let it die. Iceland has since adopted its first formal defence policy, and the clause its people asked for is still not in its constitution.

This is the furthest any state goes. Where the state conscripts, refusal is granted, examined and suspended. Where it does not, the people can write the door, vote for it, and still the state declines to install it. The gap between *decided* and *agreed* is not a flaw of particular states. It is the grammar of the state itself.

Notice, too, what actually defends a place in the Swiss model: locality, distribution, people who live there and refuse to fight anywhere else. None of that requires compulsion. A place is made costly to take by those who choose to stand in it.

The Ledger

The man who refused used to hide in a place. An attic, a barn, a forest, a cousin's village. What hid him was that the ledger was paper and local, and the people who fed him did not appear in it.

The hiding place has moved. Today he can stay home, never open the door, and still he must eat. Every payment is a timestamp and a location. Refusal once meant staying out of sight. Now it means staying out of the record, and that is far harder.

And here the grammar turns dark. The bystanders who pulled at the arms of the men at the van can still do that. But the neighbour who quietly feeds a man in hiding now buys twice as much bread, and the pattern shows. The ledger does not only find the refuser. It turns everyone who helps him into a data point. Surveillance does not need to forbid kindness. It only needs to record it.

The ledger has its own vocabulary, and it is just as gentle:

- **Financial inclusion.** To be included is to be counted.
- **Know your customer.** The bank knows you, on someone else's behalf.
- **Suspicious activity.** Here, the suspicious activity is eating while someone wants you elsewhere.

None of this needs to be imagined in full. States already link their registers to one another; the bank, the tax office and the call-up list are a few database joins apart. What remains is the last step: money that can be told what it is for.

That is what a central bank digital currency makes possible. Its designers promise it will not be programmed. But money issued, held and settled in one ledger can be instructed to stop working for a name on a list. No van required. Hunger collects him.

CBDC is the ticket to the front, for anyone who accepts it.

The Door

At the end of *The Truman Show* there is a door. A plain exit, set into the painted sky. It was always there. Truman only had to reach the edge of the set and decide to walk through it.

The ticket to the front is only issued to those who accept it. What remains when it is refused is older than any state:

- **Cash**, for as long as it lasts: it settles between two people and reports to no one.
- **Barter**, which needs no issuer, no ledger and no permission.
- **Bearer value**, held in the hand or in the head: whoever holds it, owns it.
- **The people you know**, who feed you, house you, vouch for you, and do not keep records.

The door has a price. The state advertises it as catastrophe: you will lose everything, you cannot live without an account, nobody will help you. That price is inflated on purpose. Fear is the cheapest enforcement there is.

The real price is human-sized. Some inconvenience. A smaller circle. A few things you can no longer buy, a few places you can no longer go. It is paid in effort and in friendship, and it is paid every day. It is not nothing. But it is not the wall it was painted to be. Seen at its true size, the wall shrinks back to a wall, and a wall has a door.

None of this requires a declaration. It requires a pause. When the call comes, recognise that you have a choice. Do not answer by reflex. Sign nothing for as long as you can. Say no politely, not with disdain, because accepting would be unbecoming of a person honest with themselves.

The state never gave you your life. It cannot ask for it back. It can only take it, and it can only take what it can find.